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THE BJP'S SOUTH MODEL

The Karnataka Formula

Ever since Australian John MacArthur published his upside-down 'universal corrective' map of the world in 1979, depicting the southern countries of the world on top, it has served as a useful reminder of how geographic representations subliminally shape our perception of the world. The northern Hindi heartland dominates the national political narrative. The road to Delhi passes through Lucknow, as the old adage goes. But turn the map of India upside down and the political battlefield looks very different from the rhetoric that animates conversations above the Vindhyas: 'Ali vs Bajrang Bali',[1] 'Hindu terror' or 'national/anti-national'.

From the beginning of the coalition era in 1989, the southern states have often tilted the balance of power in Delhi. The BJP, for example, lost power in 2004 largely because its then allies, the AIADMK in Tamil Nadu and the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) in Andhra Pradesh, were routed. Conversely, Vajpayee's two national electoral triumphs in 1998 and 1999 were linked to having the right winning ally in Tamil Nadu (the DMK) and a winning political arrangement in Andhra Pradesh. The 2014 and 2019 elections bucked the historical pattern because the Narendra Modi wave overrode the traditional caste-based political arithmetic in the Hindi heartland and in western India. These landslide victories masked the fact that that they were largely predicated on electoral advances in just twelve (ten in the Hindi heartland and two in the west) of India's